Contemporary politics, more often than not, is highly contested in both the academic and public domain. As Ramachandra Guha, historian of contemporary India, put it, 'those who write contemporary history know that the reader is not a passive vessel to receive the text placed before him or her. The reader is also a citizen, a *critical citizen*, with individual political and ideological preferences'.[28] Guha's dictum forms the basis of this book. Not just the reader, in the case of this book, even the protagonists that constitute this history, are not doll-like figures whose personalities and roles can be constructed or deconstructed at the author's whim or by chance discoveries of sources. Many of these actors are alive (such as many of the interviewees for this book) and have dynamic ideas and opinions. Thus, writing a book about the contemporary foreign affairs of India, specifically towards Afghanistan, is fraught with dangers. For one, there is little archival material coming to the rescue. Hidden under vast debris of classified files, a lot of admirable and appalling details about India's role in Afghanistan are out of sight, and will remain so for years to come. Hence, this book is by no means a 'complete' portrayal of India's role in Afghanistan. It does, however, exhaust most available sources to offer an analytical narrative and an explanation of why India did what it did. To this effect, the book uses a host of published and unpublished, as well as primary and secondary, sources of information.

The National Security Archives (NSA) at the George Washington University (GWU), for instance, offer declassified US intelligence dossiers and diplomatic correspondence from the 1990s. Part of the electronic briefing books of the NSA that include the 'September 11th Sourcebooks', and files on 'Middle East and South Asia', these documents highlight how Washington saw India's role in the Afghan civil war.[29] Apart from the breathtaking array of US-related documents, these electronic briefing books also include English translations of top-secret meetings of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU) from the 1980s. These documents offer priceless knowledge on the Soviet experience in Afghanistan and how Moscow viewed India's role in Afghanistan in the 1980s. Papers of John Gunther Dean, former US Ambassador to India (1985–88), supplement these documents and show how India attempted at bringing the two big powers, i.e. the US and the Soviet Union, to the talking table for resolving the Afghan imbroglio. The National Security Decision Directives, 1981–89, available